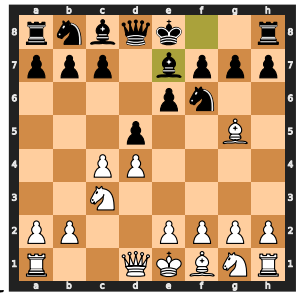
Game 1

Queen's Gambit Declined



Marshall – Capablanca

Match, 1909

White: F. J. Marshall Black: J. R. Capablanca

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.e3 ♘e4

I had played this defence twice before in the match with good results, and although I lost this game I still played it until the very last game, when I changed my tactics. The reason was my total lack of knowledge of the different variations in this opening, coupled with the fact that I knew that Dr. E. Lasker had been successful with it against Marshall himself in 1907. I thought that since Dr. Lasker had played it so often, it should be good. The object is to exchange a couple of pieces and at the same time to bring about a position full of possibilities and with promising chances of success once the end-game stage is reached. On general principles it should be wrong, because the same Knight is moved three times in the opening, although it involves the exchange of two pieces. In reality the difficulty in this variation, as well as in nearly all the variations of the Queen's gambit, lies in the slow development of Black's Queen Bishop. However, whether this variation can or cannot be safely played is a question still to be decided, and it is outside the scope of this book. I may add that at present my preference is for a different system of development, but it is not unlikely that I should some time come back to this variation.

6.♗xe7 ♕xe7 7.♗d3

7.cxd5 is preferable for reasons that we shall soon see.

7...♘xc3 8.bxc3 ♘d7

Now 8...dxc4 would be a better way to develop the game. The idea is that after 8...dxc4 9.♗xc4 b6, followed by ♗b7, would give Black's Bishop a powerful range. For this variation see the eleventh game of the match.

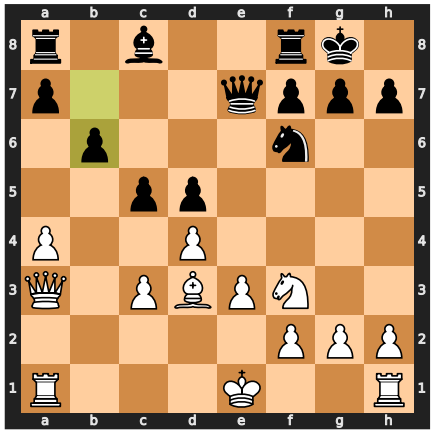
9.♘f3 0–0

No longer would 9...dxc4 10.♗xc4 b6 be good, because 11.♗b5 would prevent ♗b7 on account of ♘e5.

10.cxd5 exd5 11.♕b3 ♘f6 12.a4 c5

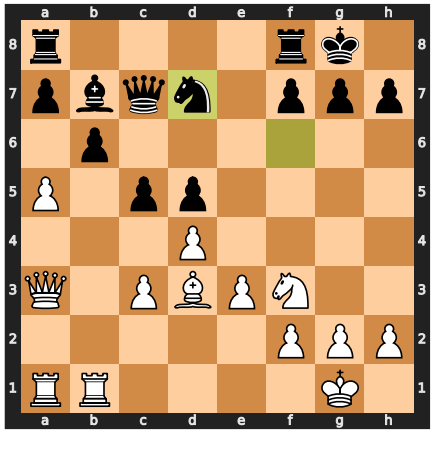
Played with the intention of obtaining the majority of Pawns on the Queen's side. Yet it is doubtful whether this move is good, since it leaves Black's Queen's-side Pawns disrupted in a way. The safer course would have been to play 12...c6.

13.♕a3 b6



This exposes Black to further attack by 14.a5 without any compensation for it. If I had to play this position nowadays I would simply play 13...♖e8. Then after 14.♕xc5 ♕xc5 would follow, and I believe that Black would regain the Pawn. If, instead, White played 14.dxc5 then 14...♗g4 would give Black an excellent game.

14.a5 ♗b7 15.0–0 ♕c7 16.♖fb1 ♘d7



Black's position was bad and perhaps lost in any case, but the text move makes matters worse. As a matter of fact I never saw White's reply 17.♗f5. It never even passed through my mind that this was threatened. Black's best move would have been 16...♖fb8. If that loses, then any other move would lose as well.

17.♗f5 ♖fc8

From bad to worse. 17...♘f6 offered the only hope.

18.♗xd7 ♕xd7 19.a6 ♗c6 20.dxc5 bxc5 21.♕xc5 ♖ab8

The game was lost. One move was as good as another.

22.♖xb8 ♖xb8 23.♘e5 ♕f5 24.f4 ♖b6 25.♕xb6!
Resigns.

Of course, if 25.♘xc6 ♖b1+ would have drawn. The text move is pretty and finishes quickly. A well-played game on Marshall's part.